Charlie

Contents

The Exiles 2
Only a Fete 3
The Golden Hair and the Cerussa 7
The King in the Labyrinth 8
The Silent Call Bell 10
The Beauty of Theatrics 14

The Exiles

TMOT-01

The Master of Theatrics

The Exiles

Charlie: Hmmm... Mr. Fool, how much further do we have to go?

The Fool: My dear Troupe Master Charlie, to which path are you referring?

The Fool: For the road to paradise has long been closed, no sign of it reopening any time soon.

The Fool: But if it's the path to hell you're after, that remains wide open, ready for our carriage to speed down and down!

Charlie: Um... N-No, that's not what I meant...

The Fool: Hah! A jest, my dear, to lighten the mood on this long journey.

The Fool: We've an hour left till we reach our destination.

Charlie: One... a whole hour?

The Fool: You seem rather surprised.

Charlie: Well... yes.

Charlie: It's only that we've already met quite a few people on our journey. I-I thought perhaps we were closer to town.

Charlie: Also there's something else... something off about this letter...

"Dear Troupe Master Charlie: we have heard of your troupe's reputation. The folks in our city wish to see you perform at our upcoming festival in five day's time."

Charlie: It's all-together strange, isn't it? Who invites a theater troupe to perform at a time like this?!

The Fool: More surprising is that you received the invitation at all.

The Fool: Only a few years back, we'd have enough of these letters to fill a wall.

Charlie: But that's... that's long since past...

Charlie: With all theater prohibited... Sending a letter like this is b-brave...

The Fool: Brave indeed. Openly defying the ban.

The Fool: But my dear Troupe Master, new laws do not restrain desires, they only make new lawbreakers.

The Fool: It is only right that we respond to the people's desires, whether there be a law or not.

Charlie: But...

The Fool: Did we not all agree on this decision, the whole troupe, including you?

Charlie: Still, I feel like we shouldn't go... What if it's a trap?!

Soldier: ...

Soldier: Pardon me, would you be the actors from the People's Troupe?

Charlie: S-soldiers!

Charlie: It is a trap! These soldiers m-must be here to arrest us!

Charlie: Run away! Run away!

The Fool: Wait, Troupe Master, no need to panic. These fine chaps don't seem interested in starting a fight.

A middle-aged man steps forward from among the soldiers.

Jeffrey: Allow me to introduce myself. I am Jeffrey, we're here to welcome you on behalf of Autonoma.

Jeffrey: Mr. Fool and I are acquainted; I believe he can attest to my identity.

Charlie: Huh? S-so you're not here to arrest us?

Jeffrey: Of course not! Why I'm as big a fan of your troupe as anyone else! Why would we do that?

Jeffrey: You must have seen all the people heading this way. They're local farmers and craftsmen on the way to Autonama for the festival.

Charlie: Oh, yes... of course, like it said in the letter- still having a festival at this time feels a bit...

Jeffrey: Dangerous?

Jeffrey: We're well aware, but this decision was made by the Mayor after weighing all the risks.

Jeffrey: The Mayor thinks people need something to celebrate in these troubled times.

Jeffrey: To avoid clashing with the Duke's ban, we're calling this a "market fair!" At least, until the show begins.

Jeffrey: We'd appreciate it if the troupe could likewise be discreet.

The Fool: Why even the foolish groundhog knows to keep his head low when a hawk's on the hunt.

Jeffrey: ...That's a sharp analogy, my friend.

Jeffrey: But either way, I want to thank you for coming and for responding to our plea despite the dangers involved.

Charlie: Y-you're too kind. We're just grateful for the chance to perform...

Jeffrey: The festival and your show will be held tomorrow. Until then, rest up and stay low.

Jeffrey: I've arranged a place to stay and some provisions for you. Follow me.

TO BE CONTINUED ...

Only a Fete

TMOT-02

Only A Fete

As night descends the following day, the once tranquil streets burst into life, abuzz with activity.

Bonfires crackled at the heart of the square, dispersing the chill and blending with the lively chatter, the scent of malt, and spices, to create a warmth that enveloped the whole crowd.

Resident: Could I have some bread? How much is it, today?

Vendor: All bread and meat are absolutely free today, courtesy of the City Council.

Resident: Free? But... what's going on here?

Before he could react, the vendor had already stuffed several loaves of bread into his hands.

Vendor: Here's your bread. And here, take a drink on the house.

The vendor bent down to pour an amber-colored ale from a nearby barrel.

Resident: A drink? This almost looks like elderberry malt to me...

As the resident took a sip from the cup. his face lit up.

Resident: This is elderberry malt!

Resident: But, what are you doing? All liquors are banned now, even arcane brews...

Resident: Wait... could it be, is this all to celebrate the festival?!

Vendor: Don't worry. It's only a "market fair" today, my friend.

The vendor gave a shrug that hid their smile.

Resident: A market fair? This looks more like a celebration to me!

Resident: I was wondering why they started lighting up the square. It seems to me you're celebrating Christmas again!

Resident: Have you lost your minds?! Did you forget about the Duke's ban on celebrations?

Vendor: Not at all, relax friend. There's no celebration here, only a "market fair."

The vendor slyly winked at the nervous citizen.

Vendor: And this? No alcohol here. Only "fermented elderberry syrup" freshly bought from an arcanist.

Resident: But it sure tastes like—

Vendor: Oy, drop the act, mate. Haven't you been waiting for a "market fair" like the rest of us?

Resident: ...

The citizen gazed down at the cup in his hand.

Resident: Well, if it's just a "market fair"... Just a 'market fair,' that's all it is...

He muttered it low, as if convincing himself.

Raising the cup, he gulped the smooth malted drink down.

"Gulp, gulp, gulp..."

Resident: Ah! Haven't had elderberry malt in ages! Packs more punch than my old homemade beer!

Vendor: Remember that's "fermented elderberry syrup," mate. Drink your fill; we've got more than enough for today.

Resident: Oh, of course, only "syrup" how silly of me.

Resident: What a wonderful "market fair" this is—all the better with some lovely "fermented elderberry syrup"!

Charlie: S-So many people...

Charlie: I haven't seen a place feel so... alive in ages.

The Fool: Of course, everyone's flocking here! It's in our nature, something we can't resist! Like moths to bright flame!

Jeffrey: We invited a great many singers and actors... Though, for obvious reasons, only a few could make it as planned.

The Fool: It makes our planned performance all the more special, don't you think?

Jeffrey: You're right!

Jeffrey: I think the People's Troupe is what everyone's most looking forward to. That's why we've arranged your performance to be our grand finale.

Jeffrey: It should be a most spectacular show.

A wooden stage covered with tents stood at the square's center, poised to become the highlight of this unspoken festival.

Charlie: You mean we—we're, the last performance?

Charlie: If I'm not mistaken, our play would be...

The Fool: Yes—You'll play an important role in it.

Charlie: No, I absolutely can't do it!

Charlie: This... This is far too rash a decision! I'm sure I'll muck it up ...

The Fool: It was a collective decision, my dear Troupe Master.

The Fool: And we have full faith in your abilities.

Old Man: Huh?

Old Man: You...you're from the King's Troupe, aren't you? Here for the "market fair" too?

Charlie: Oh... Are you... talking to us?

Old Man: Of course, young lady. I've seen the King's Troupe perform, and I recognize a fair few of the faces among you.

Old Man: Well, whether you were for the "King" or the "Minister" once, those titles have long been lost.

Old Man: With all festivals and theater prohibited. Soon, your troupes may disappear altogether.

Old Man: Festivals and theater!

Old Man: I always thought they were an untouchable part of our lives, but now, they've become unspeakable sins.

Old Man: No matter how I try to reason with myself, I just can't understand why...

The Fool: A tyrant's sin is born of unearned glory. To keep his power and fame, he will abandon all conscience.

The Fool: Our existence is a mockery of the tyrant.

The Fool: And a tyrant cannot endure mockery.

Charlie: Mm... Mr. Fool! You can't speak like that here!

Old Man: I watched your performances back then when you were known as the King's Troupe.

Old Man: I saw actors dressed in splendid costumes lined up on either side. Then, the protagonist entered, greeted with thunderous applause.

Old Man: Goodness, that was an outstanding play... Something I'll never forget!

Old Man: The theater, props, costumes, scenery—everything was so magnificent!

Charlie: Th-thank you for your praise... I'm sorry to say, I wasn't part of the troupe at that time...

Old Man: What a pity! Those were beautiful times... So different from now.

Jeffrey: I understand how you must feel. The more darker the night, the more we yearn for the daylight long past.

Jeffrey: I fear we might never witness such a scene again.

Old Man: Oh... You're right. Bringing it up only adds to the regret.

Old Man: The king's troupe has disbanded, the old theaters will be demolished, and soon... all these splendid plays will be forgotten. With none left to remember their brilliant performances.

Charlie: ...

Charlie: T-that's not true.

Charlie: They will live on. Through generations, in writings and in memories.

Charlie: They won't vanish... Not as long as people have hope in their hearts. No, they won't disappear!

Charlie: Whether it's dazzling costumes or crude rags, whether in crowded theaters or in the dark of the woods

Charlie: As long as people have hope, they'll hold true to their hearts' desires.

Charlie: So, we'll deliver a performance just as outstanding as those of the past.

Charlie: No, more! I vow to you that we'll deliver a performance that surpasses all expectations.

The Fool: I vouch for this with all the skill and artistry I have left to give.

Old Man: ...!

Old Man: I see now...

Old Man: The theater isn't about splendid costumes, but each actor's performance, the heart they bring to their role—A simple truth, long forgotten.

Old Man: I underestimated your determination... I will look forward to your performance tonight, young lady.

The old man's eyes sparkled as if a star was reborn in his eyes, and he smiled as he left the square.

The Fool: A splendid monologue, Troupe Master Charlie.

Charlie: ...

Charlie: ...

Charlie: I-I just... What was I even saying?!

Charlie: Bwaahhh... I'm so embarrassed...

Jeffrey: You shouldn't be. I'm sure of it now your troupe's performance will win over everyone.

Jeffrey: As the master of ceremonies, I should apologize, for putting you in the limelight but—

The Fool: It is plain to see everyone has high hopes for us, Troupe Master Charlie.

Charlie: Waaahhh... The pressure— it's too much! My stomach is turning...

The Fool: And yet the show must go on, my dear Troupe Master!

The Fool: As performers, it's our sacred mission to channel the audience's enthusiasm into our very best performance.

Charlie: Waaah! Make all the claims you like... But, if we mess up, we're done for!

The Fool: There's no need to panic. We will step on the stage and let our performance bring smiles or tears to the people.

The Fool: It's our calling, an unspoken bond between performers and audience.

Soldier: Mr. Jeffrey!

A breathless soldier, hurries to Jeffrey's side.

Soldier: Mr. Jeffrey, it's all gone wrong!

Jeffrey: What's wrong, soldier? Take heart, the festival is starting soon.

Soldier: It's the Duke's cavalry...

Soldier: The Duke's cavalry are approaching!

Jeffrey: What?!

TO BE CONTINUED ...

The Golden Hair and the Cerussa

TMOT-03

The Golden Hair And The Cerussa

Jeffrey: This can't be happening! The festival was supposed to be a secret...

Soldier: It's true! Our reports say that the cavalry will be here soon!

Jeffrey: Could someone have betrayed us to the Duke?

The Fool: Gah! That pathetic Comaetho is always taking the wind from our sails.

Charlie: W-what do we do now?!

Charlie: That must be the Duke's cavalry... Oh, no!

Charlie: It's time to run... Mr. Fool, we have to get out of here!

Taking a deep breath, Jeffrey regained his composure.

Jeffrey: Quick, inform the Mayor, and have him stall the cavalry.

Jeffrey: Let's proceed as planned, wrap up the festival early. Performers, use the secret passages we've prepared for your escape.

Soldier: Yes, sir!

Jeffrey: ...

Jeffrey: As I said, Troupe Master Charlie, you'd best leave now.

Jeffrey: I'm truly sorry about this... None of us wanted to put your troupe at risk!

Jeffrey: But if these knights catch wind of you, nothing good will come of it.

Charlie: I-I understand.

Charlie: Mr. Fool, we've got to get everyone out now!

Charlie: Or else they'll be right on our tails!

The Fool: Too true, Troupe Master!

The Fool: And if they chase us down, they'll strangle us, and hoist our bodies on flagpoles.

The Fool: "At that time, the crows will feast upon our flesh, like a most profane ritual."

The Fool: Alas! Alack! A terrifying outcome. We must make our exit as soon as possible.

With the performance's scheduled debut closing in, the rest of the troupe were busy with final preparations.

Troupe Member I: Troupe Master? Mr. Fool? Why are you back so soon?

Charlie: Everyone...

Clueless about what was to unfold, their fellow performers were still basking in the festive atmosphere, slow to react.

Troupe Member II: Come to check on us? Everything's set for the show!

Troupe Member I: All that was left was waiting for you, hahaha!

Costumes were unpacked and prepared, and makeup already painted on their faces.

The Fool: Oh my, what a cheerful sight.

The Fool: Of course, our actors should be excited about hitting the stage.

The Fool: It's a shame they haven't realized yet that fate has come as a muddy palm, to smear them their careful preparations!

Charlie: ...

Charlie: Everyone, I have an announcement...

But her soft voice was quickly drowned out by the excited chatter.

Troupe Member I: I'm telling you, this script will blow the audience away!

Troupe Member II: Too bad the stage setup's pretty basic this time...

Troupe Member I: Hey, don't be picky. In these times, just getting to perform is a blessing! We've got to make do with what we have!

Charlie: ...

Troupe Member II: I'm not being picky! It's only that I was up all night, imagining our performance!

Troupe Member I: I can tell! Your powder is barely covering up those dark circles—let me apply more; we can't have the audience notice.

Everyone: Hahaha!

The bursts of powder rising in the air as new makeup was applied caused a shimmering in the candlelight; Charlie had to swallow back what she was about to say.

The Fool: So much hesitation, Troupe Master Charlie? Is that stage fright?

A peculiar smile slipped through his mask.

It carried a hint of mockery and sarcasm—emotions "The Fool" had rarely laid on her.

TO BE CONTINUED ...

The King in the Labyrinth

TMOT-04

The King in The Labyrinth

The Fool: Come now, if we don't tell them, there will be no escaping.

Charlie: I just don't get it.

Charlie: These things bring joy to everyone. So why does he want to take them away?

Charlie: I—I can't wrap my head around it.

The laughter around them subsided, and worried expressions began to replace smiles on the faces of the troupe.

All turned up to Charlie as if realizing something.

Troupe Member I: Charlie... What's happened?

But as Charlie opened her mouth, not a squeak emerged.

Troupe Member II: ...

Troupe Member II: We're ready, Troupe Master.

But before she could speak, Jeffrey rushed in, panting heavily.

Jeffrey: Troupe Master Charlie! Why aren't you ready to go? The cavalry... they're almost upon us!

The Fool: So, my dear, what's holding you back?

The Fool: Anxiety? Anger? Or just plain terror?

The clown stepped onto the stage—earlier than any of the others.

Behind that comical mask lay a heart stronger than any other.

He had made his decision already.

Jeffrey: We have to go now, Troupe Master!

Charlie: Why... why does he want to take it all away?

The Fool: —Have you heard the tale of Minos?

Charlie: The tale of Minos?

The Fool: Yes, the tale of that famous king.

The Fool: When the Greek prince Minos vied for the throne, he sought divine favor to prove himself the rightful king.

The Fool: "Oh, gods," he prayed, "if you support me, grant me a white bull."

The Fool: "Then, I will sacrifice it in your honor—this shall be our pact."

The Fool: The gods answered, granting him a white bull.

The Fool: But greed led Minos to deceive them.

The Fool: He sacrificed a different bull, claiming the white one for himself.

Charlie: ...

The Fool: But though Minos had kept the white bull, he soon lost what he sought most, no longer was he a king recognized by all.

The Fool: The term "tyrant" suited him better.

Charlie: Tyrant...

The Fool: Those who play the role of a tyrant. should understand better than anyone—the nature of "him".

The Fool: A tyrant is a monster, a towering creature.

Charlie: ...Unbound to his duty, unstoppable in his wrath.

The Fool: A tyrant scorns all, seeking only power.

Charlie: ...He is greedy, hungry to devour everything in sight.

The Fool: But his arrogance will bring him crashing down. For fear cannot withstand mockery.

The Fool: Then, the once-terrified populace will rise, and a new king will lead them.

The Fool: So, have you made your choice—run or stand? Live in fear or laugh in the face of death?

Charlie: Run or stand...

Jeffrey: Hold on, Mr. Fool, do you mean...

Jeffrey: No! That's too risky!

Charlie: ...

The Fool: It seems you've made up your mind, Troupe Master Charlie.

Charlie: You're right, Mr. Fool; I have.

Charlie: I do not know what day the tyrant will fall, but until then, it's our duty to resist.

Charlie: Is our show ready?

The Fool: All the players wait for your cue, Troupe Master.

The Fool bowed his head, acknowledging her command.

Charlie closed her eyes. Reopening them with a phoenix heart, ready to begin.

Charlie: Let the show go on!

Jeffrey: Troupe Master Charlie! Don't be reckless!

Jeffrey: The rest of the citizens at the festival are under the Mayor's protection, and the cavalry have no right to harm them.

Jeffrey: But your troupe are outlaws! They are authorized to kill you on sight!

The Fool: This is far from recklessness.

The Fool: Troupe Master Charlie made her decision long ago. She only needed a gentle nudging from The Fool.

Charlie: There's no need to fear.

Charlie: Even if the tyrant brings death, we'll not stay idle in our graves!

Charlie: Should death kiss us lightly on the cheek, our struggle will be our epitaph.

Charlie: But before that—

The Fool: We'll mock the tyrant as he deserves.

Troupe Member I: We're ready, Troupe Master. the stage is set and the players have their mark!

Troupe Member II: We've been running for so long, but that doesn't mean we'll keep running forever.

Charlie: Looking upon this grand finale, where would the excitement be to flee?

Charlie: Marvelous.

Charlie: Give your best performance, and let the audience witness our struggle with their raucous applause.

The Fool: We've fled from battlefields, gallows, palaces, dungeons, and we could keep fleeing.

The Fool: But we performers owe our audience a masterful performance, no matter the circumstances...

The Fool: —That is our promise to them.

Charlie: We shall be Theseus, not Minos who tramples on his promise.

Jeffrey: ...!

Charlie: Mr. Fool, ring the bells to announce the start of our show to the audience!

Charlie: —And, of course, don't forget to invite our "special guests."

TO BE CONTINUED ...

The Silent Call Bell

TMOT-05

The Silent Call Bell

Cavalry: Hurry! Don't let them slip away!

A swift squad of knights races through the streets, their torches illuminating the night.

Cavalry: Stay indoors, everyone! Not one step out!

Cavalry: This time, we will catch them!

The clash of metal armor and loud commands echoed through the streets.

The town square, in the heart of the city, was in disarray, with no one to be seen.

Until the distant bells chimed.

As if declaring or beckoning:

???: Come one, come all.

At the far end of the street, a clown with exaggerated makeup appeared, clutching a torch.

The Fool: Congratulations! You've captured us poor souls, who've suffered so unjustly.

Cavalry: You...you're that outlaw from the wanted posters!

The Fool: Wanted?

The Fool: What a laugh! Who gives meaning to those useless scraps of paper?

Cavalry: They are the Duke's command! No one dares disobey!

Charlie: And who gave him the power to give these commands?

A performer in elegant attire emerged on the opposite side of the street, coolly observing the multitude of knights.

Cavalry: What nonsense are you spouting?

Charlie: Why, it's the people.

Charlie: They gave him that power.

Charlie: But then he violated their trust, and he lost the power they gave him.

Charlie: And tyrants quake at its happening—

Charlie: Just as King John feared Arthur, Claudius feared Hamlet, and Macbeth feared Malcolm.

Charlie: The usurper fears the true wielder of his power.

Charlie: He fears us—fears the true holders of that power.

Cavalry: Enough! Stop this deceitful talk! Seize them all!

Charlie: But first, let us savor our final act.

Once more, the distant bells rang out.

Charlie: That is your cue, Mr. Fool.

The Fool: As you wish.

The clown raised his torch and flung it aside.

Flames swiftly spread from the torch to the buildings lining both sides of the street.

The fire escalated rapidly, transforming the street into an impassable wall of flames.

Cavalry: What are you doing... have you all lost your minds?!

Cavalry: Quick! On my mark, turn back and retreat!

Soldier: Captain! The way back is blocked!

The cavalry captain turned in shock.

Suddenly, a large crowd gathered around Charlie.

Silent and unmoving, they stood like an impenetrable wall.

Charlie: You thugs, did I not warn you? This is the final act—but not ours, yours.

Charlie: Savor your last gasp of fear, for on its tail quickly comes...the anger of the people!

Soldier: Captain! There's nobody on the other side of the street. We can break through there!

Soldier: Wait...are they forcing us to break through ahead?

Cavalry: These blasted troublemakers...

Soldier: I see it now!

Soldier: They fear the Duke's might!

Soldier: They won't dare kill us! They fear the Duke's retaliation, so they're forcing us out through another gate!

Cavalry: What a despicable lot, daring to turn against their betters!

Soldier: Captain, if we don't run now, it'll be too late!

As the fear heightened the cavalry leader seemed to remember something.

Cavalry: No, no! I won't fall for this!

A confident smile spread across his face.

Cavalry: Hah, your performance was compelling. It almost fooled me!

Cavalry: But alas, arcanist, your act lacked a certain spark.

Charlie: What are you babbling on about, you up-jumped stable boy!

Cavalry: I've heard of you and your arcane illusions. This is all your trick, isn't it?

Charlie: An interesting conclusion...

Cavalry: Hah, these flames, this crowd... They are mere illusions you created!

Cavalry: You're just making a blustering show of bravado, but your nothing more than fools!

Charlie: ...

Despite delivering a pinnacle performance, Charlie's expression momentarily wavered.

The cavalryman revealed a smug smile, convinced he'd spotted his adversary's weakness.

Charlie: See for yourself whether it's real or an illusion.

Cavalry: Still want to play the braggadocio, eh? Get her!

Cavalry: You dare to resist the Duke's power with cheap illusions...

Cavalry: Honestly, your actions are as laughable as your sorcery.

Cavalry: Get her! Take her away!

Suddenly, the bells chimed again, but this time, they sounded unusually long, ringing out a different tune.

The echoes of the bells faded, replaced by a different sound.

The sound of footsteps.

A vast thunder of steps approached from all directions, and soon, flickering torchlights dotted every alley of the street.

With this new crowd converged behind Charlie.

Charlie: ...!

Jeffrey: Stop! I am Jeffrey from the City Council!

Jeffrey: Your actions are hereby condemned by the Council! On behalf of the City Council of Autonoma, we order you to leave now!

Charlie: What's this...?!

Cavalry: City Council?! Do you even know who we are?!

Old Man: Nothing more than henchmen of a tyrant, get out!

Vendor: You're not welcome here!

Resident: Leave! Leave now!

As the furious crowd gathered behind Charlie, the flames on both sides of the street roared higher.

The temperature rose, and beads of sweat formed on the henchmens' foreheads.

Soldier: C-Captain, t-this doesn't look like an illusion anymore!

Soldier: I've never heard of any arcanist creating something like this...

Cavalry: It's all an illusion, you cowards! Here, let me show you...

The captain of the cavalry gritted his teeth and charged into the burning flames.

Cavalry: Damn it! It's scorching! It's- it's real fire?!

Charlie: Indeed! And it burns with the people's rage.

Charlie: And should you trample on the people, then they'll reclaim their power.

Charlie: That which rightfully belongs with them.

Charlie: Respect a just ruler, but ever resist a tyrant—

Charlie: This is the reckoning of the people.

Charlie: Still think these angry crowds are just an illusion?

Cavalry: You dare—

The cavalryman's words were cut off by a rotten egg thrown from the crowd.

Though it bounced harmlessly from his heavy armor, the humiliation pierced him deeper than any bolt or arrow.

Charlie: Still think this is just a trick?

The bells...

The bells rang louder and more fervently.

They sounded like they were urging a final judgment.

The captain's spirit finally crumbled.

Cavalry: Madmen... a bunch of madmen!

Cavalry: How dare you rabble defy the Duke's—

His muttered words were consumed by the crowd's condemnation.

Charlie: Don't say I didn't warn you. Leave now while you still can.

Charlie: ...Or face the fury of the people.

She raised a hand, and the crowd parted, creating a path behind her.

Cavalry: Damn it... let's go... let's go! Retreat, retreat!

The soldiers meekly sheathed their weapons and retreated towards the city gate.

Old Man: That's it! Don't show your faces here again!

Laughter erupted among the crowd.

The soldiers' arrogance had given way to dejection, in stark contrast to their previous bravado.

TO BE CONTINUED ...

The Beauty of Theatrics

TMOT-06

The Beauty of Theatrics

Charlie: ...

The cavalry left the town, dejected and broken.

As the gates closed, the bells chimed once more.

But this time, its toll was slow and drawn out.

Charlie: They're...

Charlie: They're gone...?

Charlie staggered back as if drained of all her strength.

She gasped violently, filling her lungs with air.

Charlie: T-they...really left?!

As she tried to compose herself, the people around her and the burning buildings lining the streets began to sway.

Finally, the whole scene shattered like a popped bubble, revealing the true appearance of the street.

The festive bonfire continued to blaze in the square, its flames turning the surroundings as bright as day.

But only a small portion of the crowd had vanished; more people remained behind her.

Yes, it wasn't an illusion, but rather they had been all, or almost all, too real.

After a few moments of silence, a cheer erupted from the crowd.

Old Man: We did it! I can't believe it, we actually drove them away!

Vendor: Hurrah!

The Fool: A flawless performance, Troupe Master Charlie! A flawless performance!

The Fool: A haunting performance of unprecedented magnitude!

Charlie: L—Let's not talk about it anymore!

Charlie: Oh... I... I was so scared. Just thinking about what happened... I can't stop shaking!

Jeffrey: You... You did it! You really scared off the Duke's men!

Charlie: No... I didn't do anything at all! I might have put everyone at risk!

Charlie: If it weren't for all of you ... my poor tricks would've been exposed ...

Old Man: There's no need to be modest. You gave us the courage to resist. We came together because of your call.

Jeffrey: This is an outright victory, Troupe Master Charlie.

Jeffrey: You gave them a taste of their own medicine and taught them a lesson for all of us.

Charlie: R-Really...?

The Fool: Mr. Jeffrey was right. These knights will never reveal what happened today.

The Fool: The tyrant's lackeys rely on lies and fear to maintain power, fearing people might discover how weak he truly is...

Jeffrey: Their actions are driven by self-interest. They won't speak of this; it would never serve their purpose.

Charlie: That's amazing! We really did it!

The Fool: But, Troupe Master Charlie, I must remind you of something.

The Fool: Though emotions will run high for now, please don't forget there's another act still to come.

Charlie: Something greater still...

Charlie: Oh!

The Fool: Our earlier performance was but a dress rehearsal. What's comes next is the real show, the most crucial of our performances.

The Fool: The eager crowd has already gathered; step onto the stage and answer their call.

With the bells tolling, their audience converged on the square from all directions.

The Fool: Their faces filled with anticipation for a performance befitting the festival.

Charlie: ...Yes, yes! You're right, Mr. Fool! Now begins the most important part of the show!

She took a deep breath, her expression turning serious.

It was the same look she always wore when she stepped onto the stage.

Charlie: Let's get started, Mr. Fool.

Charlie: May we echo the promise we made to our audience and let them know that the theater we cherish won't end here.

Charlie: Because the joy of theater can have a lasting impact.

Charlie: It can overcome hardship, defeat fear, and even conquer the greed of Minos.

Charlie: Yes, even if it's an illusion, what people experience is far from some meaningless bubble.

The Fool: That is where our little story ends. I wonder, Miss Vertin, was the story to your satisfaction?

The Fool: You see, that is the true meaning of theater.

The Fool: Whether real or illusory, people will find in the performance an inspiration to resonate with.

The Fool: Were you wondering about which play the troupe is performing?

The Fool: If you ask me, it's still a little too early for Christmas.

The Fool: But for a story like this, ending it with a little comedy seemed quite fitting.

The Fool: I'm curious... What do you think?

The Fool: Oh, there's no need to answer. I believe deep down inside, you already know.

The Fool: —But all this remaining the same, I hope you enjoyed the story.

THE END